which I could put most of my effort while still working on black holes and other things part time. Inspired by Weber, I chose gravitational waves.

Like Weber, I saw gravitational waves as an infant research field with a bright future. By entering the field in its infancy, I could have the fun of helping mold it, I could lay foundations on which others later would build, and I could do so without others breathing down my neck, since most other relativity theorists were then focusing on black holes.

For Weber, the foundations to be laid were experimental: the invention, construction, and continual improvement of detectors. For me, they were theoretical: try to understand what Einstein's gravitational laws have to say about how gravitational waves are produced, how they push back on their sources as they depart, and how they propagate; try to figure out which kinds of astronomical objects will produce the Universe's strongest waves, how strong their waves will be, and with what frequencies they will oscillate; invent mathematical tools for computing the details of the encoded symphonies produced by these objects, so when Weber and others ultimately detect the waves, theory and experiment can be compared.

In 1969 I spent six weeks in Moscow, at Zel'dovich's invitation. One day Zel'dovich took time out from bombarding me and others with new ideas (Chapters 7 and 12), and drove me over to Moscow University to introduce me to a young experimental physicist, Vladimir Braginsky. Braginsky, stimulated by Weber, had been working for several years to develop techniques for gravitational-wave detection; he was the first experimenter after Weber to enter the field. He was also in the midst of other- fascinating experiments: a search for *quarks* (a fundamental building block of protons and neutrons), and an experiment to test Einstein's assertion that all objects, no matter what their composition, fall with the same acceleration in a gravitational field (an assertion that underlies Einstein's description of gravity as spacetime curvature).

I was impressed. Braginsky was clever, deep, and had excellent taste in physics; and he was warm and forthright, as easy to talk to about politics as about science. We quickly became close friends and learned to respect each other's world views. For me, a liberal Democrat in the American spectrum, the freedom of the individual was paramount over all other considerations. No government should have the right to dictate how one lives one's life. For Braginsky, a nondoctrinaire Communist, the responsibility of the individual